

FRANKLIN STREET COMMERCIAL HISTORIC DISTRICT
Bounded by 4th, Franklin, 11th, and Pine Streets
Michigan City
La Porte County
Indiana

HABS IN-324
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PHOTOGRAPHS

WRITTEN HISTORICAL AND DESCRIPTIVE DATA

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
National Park Service
Interior Regions 3, 4, and 5
U.S. Department of the Interior
601 Riverfront Drive
Omaha, NE 68102

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
FRANKLIN STREET COMMERCIAL HISTORIC DISTRICT

HABS No. IN-324

Location:	The Franklin Street Commercial Historic District is located in downtown Michigan City, LaPorte County, Indiana. The district is bound by 4th Street on the north, Franklin Street on the west, 11th Street on the south, and Pine Street on the east.
Date(s) of Construction:	ca. 1880 - 1927
Architect:	Various
Builder:	Various
Present Owner:	Various
Present Use:	Commerce/Trade Transportation Vacant
Significance:	The Franklin Street Commercial Historic District was listed in the National Register of Historic Places (NRHP) in 2013 under Criterion A for its role in regional industry and commerce. Michigan City was an important center for regional commerce due to its location on Lake Michigan and its proximity to industrial establishments in Gary and Chicago. Following construction of the railroad through Michigan City in the 1850s, commercial activity relocated from Front Street to Franklin Street, where it remained thereafter. Franklin Street is also significant under Criterion C for its exemplary collection of commercial and residential buildings built in a variety of styles that include most prominently Italianate and Colonial Revival. The NRHP-listed period of significance for the commercial historic district is 1867-1963.
Historians:	Written description and historic research prepared by Diana Garnett and Jeanne Barnes, HDR Engineering, Inc., August 2020.

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Description: The Franklin Street Commercial District is bound by 4th Street on the north, Franklin Street on the west, 11th Street on the south, and Pine Street on the east. The district, which additionally includes some religious, civic, and residential properties, constitutes part of Michigan City's original plat. Buildings were constructed between 1867 and 1963.

The majority of buildings in Franklin Street Commercial Historic District are commercial in use, though small areas of residential properties as well as churches are included within the boundaries as well. Historic commercial buildings, most of which stand along Franklin Street, facing east or west, are commonly of brick construction, two stories in height, and share walls with neighboring storefronts. Architectural features are typically classical or Italianate in style, including details such as pedimented or segmental brick window hoods, oriel bay windows, double hung sash windows, and cornice moldings and brackets. Roofs are typically flat, and sometimes obscured behind parapet walls. Commercial buildings also usually feature glass window storefronts with central recessed, double leaf doorways. More elaborate commercial buildings include a Beaux Arts terra cotta building (601 Franklin); a three-story Classical Revival building with fluted pilasters and a classical frieze and dentils (518-522 Franklin); and a Spanish Mission-style building with a clay tile pent roof and heavy molded cornice and brackets (622 Franklin); and the Beaux Arts South Shore Station at 114 11th Street.

Residential buildings in the historic district stand along the side streets (4th Street–11th Street) as well as along Washington Street and Pine Street. Dwellings are typically wood-frame with brick veneer or replacement siding and one-and-a-half or two stories in height. A range of architectural types and styles is included in the district: the majority of homes are gable-front in form, but present in smaller numbers are brick bungalows and foursquares.

Most residential and commercial buildings in the historic district have undergone some degree of modification, obscuring or eliminating original stylistic details. Additionally, many of the historic dwellings along Washington and Pine Streets have been removed, leaving parcels of vacant land or parking lots.

The historic district is laid out on a grid pattern with a titled axis. Franklin Street, the central north(west)-south(east) axis, is two-lane, bidirectional, and asphalt-paved. Diagonal parking spaces line both sides of the street. Concrete sidewalks are present on both sides of the street. Buildings typically have little or no setback, opening directly onto the sidewalk. The sidewalks are punctuated with small elements of landscaping including flower beds and young-middle-age deciduous trees. Side streets and

Washington and Pine Streets are also bi-directional, asphalt-paved, and flanked by concrete sidewalks with grassy banks. Dwellings along these streets are typically set back at a shallow distance from the sidewalk, with small grassy yards wrapping around buildings. Most blocks in the historic district are bisected by an east-west alley way. Some properties include a separate garage building that faces north or south into the alley way.

The level of integrity in the historic district is moderate, with many buildings having replacement materials, replacement windows and doors, and modified porches. Some historic buildings have been demolished in recent decades, leaving vacant parcels. The 6 individual properties included in this survey are described individually below. Construction dates were generally provided by LaPorte County GIS, with reference and comparison made to other historic documentation including historic Sanborn Fire Insurance maps and the NRHP nomination for Franklin Street Commercial Historic District.

A. 1019 Franklin Street – Commercial Building, ca. 1925.

The one-story brick commercial building is located on the northwest corner of 11th Street and Franklin Street, and faces east-northeast onto Franklin Street. The building shares a wall and a storefront façade (east wall) with the adjacent property to the north, 1017 Franklin Street. 1019 occupies the south quarter of the building, with 1017 in the north three-quarters. The building is constructed of brick, load-bearing walls, and capped by a flat roof that is obscured behind a stepped parapet wall with a metal cap. A raised, geometrical brick relief ornaments the center of the upper façade wall. The historic 1017 storefront has been infilled with vertical wood or T1-11 siding. The facade is symmetrical, three bays wide and recessed. The two outer bay walls are angled inward to the center entrance bay, a single-leaf metal-frame glass door. Each outer façade bay contains a square, wood-frame, fixed storefront window. The storefront lintel is clad in replacement vertical wood siding, and forms a heavy overhang above the recessed entrance. A three-dimensional synthetic sign is fixed to the overhang, reading “Firme Office & Art Supplies.” The infilled façade bays are framed by original brick coursework. The south (side) wall that fronts 11th Street contains two fixed wood storefront windows in the front (east) bays. Above these are two wood infill panels, capped by a brick soldier header course. A raised brick relief circle ornaments the upper wall. The south side brick wall extends halfway down (west) the block along 11th Street, with no additional fenestration except a set of double-leaf metal doors in the rear bay. A large painted decal reading “Firme Office & Art Supplies” covers part of the south wall.

Historic Sanborn Fire Insurance maps show that in 1929, 1019 Franklin Street was a drugstore. Its brick construction and shared wall were present by this time, and the attached business at 1017 Franklin was identified as a bake shop. 1019 Franklin Street remained a drug store through at least 1936.¹ In the 1950s and 1960s, the building was a hardware shop.² The present arts supply business, owned by Glenn Firme & Associates, acquired the property in 1998.³

B. 1017 Franklin Street – Commercial Building, ca. 1925.

The one-story brick commercial building is located on the northwest corner of 11th Street and Franklin Street, and faces east-northeast onto Franklin Street. The building shares a wall and a storefront façade (east wall) with the adjacent property to the south, 1019 Franklin Street. 1017 occupies the north three-quarters of the building, with 1019 in the south quarter. The building is constructed of brick, load-bearing walls, and capped by a flat roof that is obscured behind a stepped parapet wall with a metal cap. A raised, geometrical brick relief ornaments the center of the upper façade wall. The storefront on 1017 is a symmetrical eight bays wide. The two central bays are recessed, and consist of two adjacent single-leaf, metal-frame glass doors with transoms, separated by a central metal mullion. Three large, fixed, metal-frame storefront windows flank the doors on either side (north and south). The storefront lintel is faced with non-historic cut stone or simulated cut stone veneer. Soldier brick courses frame the 1017 storefront. At the time of survey, the property was vacant, and no signs were affixed to the lintel.

Historic Sanborn Fire Insurance maps show that in 1929, 1017 Franklin Street was a bakeshop. Its brick construction and shared wall were present by this time, and the attached business at 1019 Franklin was identified as a drug store.⁴ By the 1950s and 1960s, the building was a hardware shop.⁵

C. 106 E. 11th Street – Commercial Building, ca. 1925.

The one-story brick commercial building is located on the north side of 11th Street and faces south. The rectangular-plan building contains two storefronts separated by an interior wall. The building sits on a slightly

¹ Sanborn Map Company, *Insurance Maps of Michigan City, Indiana, LaPorte County* (New York: Sanborn Map Company), 1929; 1936, sheets 6, 9.

² Kurt West Garner, Franklin Street Commercial Historic District NRHP Nomination Form (Washington DC: US Department of the Interior, NPS), 2013, 15.

³ Information regarding recent ownership history acquired through the Beacon, a local government GIS tax lot search website. Beacon 2020, “Local Government GIS for the Web,” <https://beacon.schneidercorp.com/?site=La%20PorteCountyIN>, accessed May 2020.

⁴ Sanborn Map Company 1929, sheet 6.

⁵ Garner 2013, 15.

raised concrete foundation and is constructed of concrete walls with brick veneer. It is capped by a flat roof that is obscured by tiered, gabled parapet with concrete coping. The double-front façade (south wall) is mostly symmetrical. Each half contains a recessed pair of metal-frame glass doors with transoms, separated by a central mullion and flanked by fixed, metal-frame storefront windows. Brick detailing work on the façade includes interlock brick corners where central storefront bays angle inwards towards entrance; brick soldier lintel course and cornice; and parquet coursework on the upper façade wall. The majority of the brick is laid in running bond.

D. 1010 Franklin Street – Commercial Building, ca. 1890.

The two-story commercial building stands on the east side of Franklin Street and faces west. The building is wood frame with a running bond, painted brick veneer. The building sits at-grade and the foundation is not visible. It is capped by a flat roof with a replacement parapet of standing seam metal. The first story façade (west wall) is symmetrical with a central, recessed metal-frame glass door flanked by metal-frame storefront windows angled inwards towards the door, and which wrap around to each side wall. Windows extend nearly floor to ceiling in height. The lintel above the storefront is clad in replacement T1-11 siding. At the time of survey, the building was vacant, and no sign was fixed to the façade lintel; a synthetic box sign is affixed to the lintel on the south (side) wall, reading “Studio II tattooing and body piercing.” Three replacement windows in original single sash openings are located on the second story. Windows rest on concrete sills and have pedimented concrete hoods with decorative floral engravings. Single sash openings on both side walls are mostly boarded.

Historic Sanborn Fire Insurance maps show that a two-story wood dwelling stood at this location prior to construction of 1010 Franklin Street c. 1890. In 1899, the building is identified as a grocery store. The National Register nomination form for the Franklin Street Commercial Historic District identifies this business as the Evert Grocery, constructed by Louis Evert c. 1894. Ghost lettering that remains on the upper south wall of 1010 reads “Frosty’s Cajun Bar BQ Hickory Smokehouse.” Between 1905 and 1912, a one-story, wood-frame, brick-faced barber shop was built onto the south side of 1010. This addition was expanded further south in the 1920s, but the expansion was removed by 1936. The barber shop reportedly continued to operate through the 1950s and 1960s. It is unclear when the south-side barber shop was removed, or when the tattoo parlor moved in.

E. 121 E. 10th Street – Single-Family Dwelling, ca. 1880.

The two-story, wood frame gable-and-wing dwelling stands on the south side of 10th Street and faces north. The building has an L-plan. It is clad in vinyl siding, and sits on a raised foundation, which appears to be concrete. The building is capped by a cross-gable roof with closed overhanging eaves, and covered in asphalt shingles. A pent roof covered in asphalt shingles stretches across the full façade (north wall) of the front-gable (east) wing, providing a covering over a shallow, full-width concrete porch with metal balustrade. The single-leaf door is located in the east bay of façade, and appears to be a wood sash door with a fixed light, but is mostly obscured by a metal storm door. A non-original picture window is located west of the door. Remaining windows on both stories of the façade and original side walls are single 1/1 double hung sash, covered by metal or vinyl storms. A small concrete side porch is present on the east wall. Two gabled-extensions at the rear (south) of the L-plan were constructed by 1889.

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Project
Information:

The HABS documentation for the Franklin Street Commercial Historic District, Michigan City is being completed to satisfy the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) between the Federal Transit Administration and the Indiana State Historic Preservation Officer Regarding the Double Track Northwest Indiana Project (Project), executed December 8, 2017. The Project as proposed by the Northern Indiana Commuter Transportation District (NICTD) requires the demolition of six contributing resources to the NRHP-listed historic district. The MOA stipulates that appropriate mitigation for the adverse effect caused by the proposed demolition is the

completion of a HABS Documentation Level III (Short Form) Report for the district and its contributing resources being demolished.

This HABS report documents only the buildings in the historic district that will be demolished to accommodate proposed improvements to the South Shore Line. These buildings are located on the north side of 11th Street between Washington Street on the west and Pine Street on the east. Five of the six resources are documented in this report; the sixth building, the South Shore Station, has been documented individually on its own HABS report. NICTD contracted with HDR Engineering, Inc. to complete the HABS documentation for the Project. HDR architectural historians Diana Garnett and Jeanne Barnes completed the historic research and write up for the HABS report. Large format photography was provided by Leslie Schwartz in December 2019.